



Iguana

Iguanas are a type of plant-eating lizard that live in tropical areas like Mexico, Central America, South America, and the Caribbean. They were first described in 1768 by a scientist named Josephus Nicolaus Laurenti. There are two main types of iguanas: the green iguana, which is common and often kept as a pet, and the Lesser Antillean iguana, found in the Lesser Antilles. Scientists think the green iguana might actually be a group of different species, but they are usually considered subspecies of the green iguana.

The word "iguana" comes from the Taino name "iwana." Besides the two species in the Iguana group, there are other related groups in the same family that also have "iguana" in their names.

The species is a popular pet and has been introduced to places outside its native area, like Ishigaki Island, the Florida Peninsula, Hawaii, Singapore, Thailand, Taiwan, and many islands in the Lesser Antilles where iguanas already live.

Anatomy and physiology

Iguanas are big lizards that can be about 4 to 6.5 feet long, including their tails. They have a flap of skin under their neck called a dewlap and a line of long scales from their necks to their tails. Iguanas have different kinds of scales on their bodies. For example, they have some big, round scales on the sides of their necks mixed with smaller ones. The scales on their backs are thicker and closer together than the ones on their bellies. These scales can be different colors and might not be easy to see up close. They also have a big, round scale on their cheeks called a subtympanic shield.

Iguanas have really good eyesight. They can see shapes, shadows, colors, and movement from far away. This helps them move through thick forests and find food. They also use their sight to send signals to other iguanas.

The tympanum, which is the iguana's eardrum, is found above the ear shield behind each eye.

Iguana

Temporal range:



A green iguana (*Iguana iguana*)

Conservation status

CITES Appendix II (CITES)^[3]

Scientific classification

Domain:	<u>Eukaryota</u>
Kingdom:	<u>Animalia</u>
Phylum:	<u>Chordata</u>
Class:	<u>Reptilia</u>
Order:	<u>Squamata</u>
Suborder:	<u>Iguania</u>
Family:	<u>Iguanidae</u>
Genus:	<u><i>Iguana</i></u> <u>Laurenti, 1768</u>

Type species

Iguana iguana
Linnaeus, 1758

Species

Iguanas are usually hard to see because they blend in with their surroundings. Their color helps them hide from bigger animals that might want to eat them.

Like most reptiles, an iguana has a heart with three parts: two atria and one ventricle. It also has two aortae for blood circulation. The iguana's muscles are light-colored because they have a lot of fast-twitch muscle fibers, called type A. These fibers don't have many blood vessels and have low myoglobin, which makes them look pale. This means iguanas can move really fast for a short time, but they can't keep it up for long because these fibers use energy without oxygen.

Parietal eye

Some lizards, like iguanas, have a light-colored scale on the back of their heads called the parietal eye. This special part can sense light changes and tells the pineal gland when it's day or night. A photopigment called parapinopsin, also found in lampreys, helps iguanas detect ultraviolet light and helps with day and night signaling.

Skull morphology and diet

Iguanas eat only plants and leaves. To chew and digest plants, plant-eating lizards need to bite harder compared to meat-eating or mixed-diet reptiles. Iguanas have strong jaws that help them eat plants well. Their heads are taller and wider, with shorter noses and bigger bodies than meat-eating or mixed-diet reptiles. This makes their skulls stronger, allowing more muscles and helping them handle stronger forces.

Iguanas have acrodontal teeth, which means their teeth sit on top of their jaw bone and point upwards. These teeth are small and have jagged edges, perfect for grabbing and cutting food.

Reproduction

Male iguanas, like other male lizards, have two special organs called hemipenes. When they mate, one hemipenis is used. Female iguanas can keep sperm from past mates for years. This way, they can still fertilize their eggs even if there are no males around when they need to lay eggs again.

Mating/courtship

- Lesser Antillean iguana, *I. delicatissima*
- Green iguana, *I. iguana*

Synonyms

- *Hypsilophus* Wagler, 1830



A male green iguana



Iguanas have an exclusively herbivorous diet,^[15] as illustrated above by a green iguana eating a mango in Venezuela.

Iguanas usually have many partners during the dry season. They mate then so their babies hatch in the rainy season when there's more food. Female iguanas have big areas where they make several nests. Males try to win over the females and mark their own area with a special scent from their back legs. When males compete, they bob their heads, move a flap of skin under their chin, nuzzle, bite the females' necks, and sometimes change color. When a female picks a male, he holds onto her by biting her shoulder, which can leave marks. After mating, the eggs are laid in nests and left to hatch on their own. This shows that iguanas don't take much care of their young, which is called r-strategy reproduction.

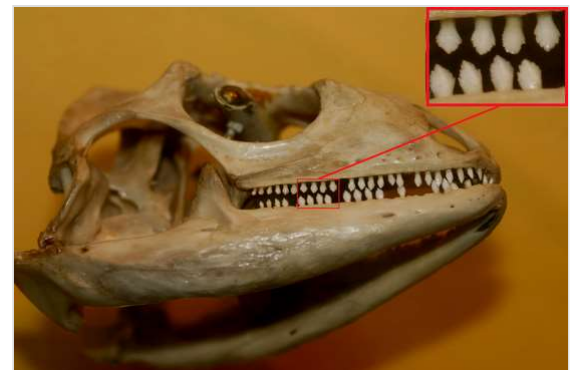
Phylogeny

A study by Vidal and Hedges in 2009 showed that iguanas are in a group with snakes and some lizards. These animals have a special gland in their mouths that can release toxins. Another study by Rest and others in 2003, using different methods, found that the green iguana is closely related to the mole skink. Lepidosaurs are reptiles with scales that overlap. In this group, both iguanas and tuataras use their tongues to catch food instead of their jaws. This is called tongue prehension. Iguanas are the only ones in their group that do this, which means they developed it separately from tuataras. Iguanas also mainly use their eyes to find and follow prey, unlike others that use smell. They catch prey by waiting and ambushing instead of actively searching.

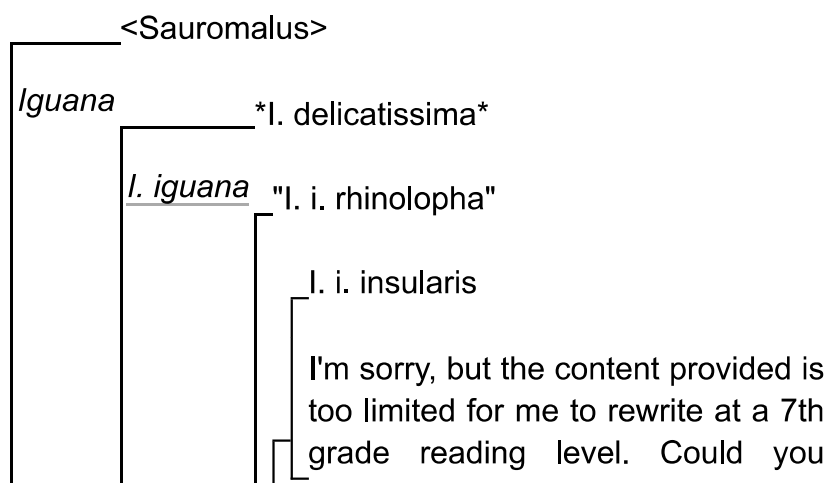
A study by Breuil et al. (2020) looked at how iguanas are grouped. They found that *I. delicatissima* is the earliest member of the iguana group. The species are sorted into subspecies using the ReptileDatabase definitions.



Albino Iguana - Bred to be kept as a pet



Green iguana skull and teeth: The teeth of the green iguana sit on the surface of the jawbone, known as acrodontal placement.^[18]

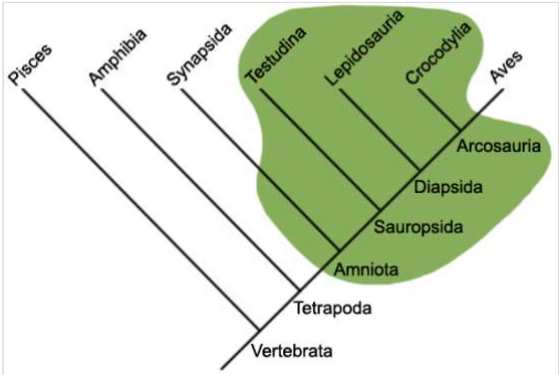


provide more information or context?

I'm sorry, but there isn't enough information in the content to rewrite it for a 7th-grade reading level.

Could you provide more details or context?

I. i. iguana



The Reptile Database says that *I. rhinolopha* is just a special group of *I. iguana*. It also lists *I. insularis* and *I. melanoderma* as types of *I. iguana*. There are four kinds of green iguana: *I. i. insularis* (found in Saint Vincent & the Grenadines and Grenada), *I. i. sanctaluciae* (found in Saint Lucia), *I. i. melanoderma* (found in parts of the northern Lesser Antilles, and maybe coastal Venezuela, the Virgin Islands, and Puerto Rico), and *I. i. iguana* (found in mainland South America).

Extant species

There are two well-known species in the Iguana group that are still alive today.

Image	Scientific name	Common name	Distribution
	<i>Iguana delicatissima</i>	Lesser Antillean iguana	The Lesser Antilles on Saint Barth, Anguilla, Sint Eustatius, Guadeloupe, Dominica, and Martinique
	<i>Iguana iguana</i>	Green iguana	Most of South America, from Colombia east to French Guiana and south to northern Argentina. Also introduced to parts of the Caribbean. If other species formerly considered conspecific are included, ranges north to southern Mexico and the southern Caribbean; specifically Grenada, Aruba, Curaçao, Trinidad and Tobago, St. Lucia, St. Vincent, and Utila.

Subspecies

There are three types of green iguanas found in the Caribbean.

Image	Subspecies	Common name	Distribution
	<i>I. i. insularis</i> ^[26]	<u>Grenadines horned iguana</u>	<u>St. Vincent and the Grenadines</u> and Grenada
	<i>Iguana iguana melanoderma</i> ^[6]	<u>Saban black iguana</u>	Saba, Montserrat, and formerly Redonda, but also possibly coastal Venezuela, the Virgin Islands, and Puerto Rico (at least parts of this range may derive from (pre)historic introductions).
	<i>I. i. sanctaluciae</i> ^[26]	<u>Saint Lucia horned iguana</u>	St. Lucia

The Central American iguana, sometimes thought to be a different species, is mostly seen as the same as *I. iguana*. Just because it has horns doesn't mean it's a new species. There are two subspecies of *I. insularis*: the Saint Lucia horned iguana and the Grenadines horned iguana. They were first thought to be subspecies of *I. iguana*, but they are very similar genetically and might not be separate. Some recent studies say *I. rhinolopha* and *I. insularis* are different species based on genetics. However, the Reptile Database disagrees, saying *I. rhinolopha* is the same as *I. iguana*, and *I. insularis* is a subspecies of *I. iguana*. The green iguanas in Curaçao are very different genetically and might be a new species or subspecies that hasn't been described yet.

As food

Iguanas have been part of the food traditions in Mexico and Central America for a long time. People also eat iguana meat in some areas of the United States and Puerto Rico. In places like Nicaragua and Colombia, iguana eggs are eaten too.

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